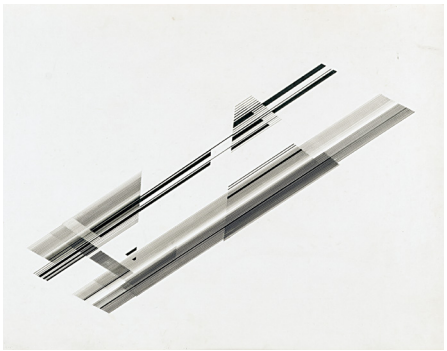




QUIET ELEGANCE
A photo of Nasreen Mohamedi by Jyoti Bhatt (1961); Line Drawing (1980); Painting (1985)

The works of Nasreen Mohamedi have the effect of Zen Koans, evoking questions that defy answers

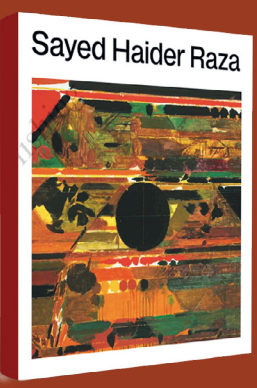


deftly paused to create shape gaps around void space. In these breathtaking absences, the geometry comes alive, acquiring philosophical dimensions alluding to Zen, Sufi and Daoist influences on the artist's thought. In the tight meter of the repetitive parallel lines, Mohamedi introduces subtle anomalies of angle to create ripples of asymmetry in the otherwise austere and mathematical patterns. In places, she creates illusions of curves by joining straight lines in angled precision. It is still abstract geometry, but imbued with movement and play. In some works, the pressure on the pen's tip is shifted to bring subtle tonal gradations in the same line, creating forms that appear to be submerged in water or coalescing out of nothingness. The surge of feelings they evoke rouses us like the wordless alaap of a raga. We are left in a pulsating void of heightened awareness—a 'satori' moment.

The show also has several of Mohamedi's photographs—mostly abstract compositions of road markings and architectural forms—which displayed along with the artworks induce an anomalous reading of them as representational sources of her geometric language. However, seen independently, they divulge a seeing process that strips the photographed subjects of all identity and symbolism and reduces them to detached geometry. Mohamedi appears using the camera viewfinder as a training device, for the eye to silence its seeing. As such, these photographs are vital clues for understanding the artist's practice, which is to cleanse the lines of all allusions, all sediments of meanings and free them from even a shadow of the self. ■

Bandeep Singh

(Works by Nasreen Mohamedi from the collection of Glenbarra Art Museum, Japan, are on display in Delhi at the Vadehra Art Gallery till March 2 and at Bikaner House from March 10 to April 4, and in Mumbai at the Pundole Art Gallery from April 20 to May 26)



SAYED HAIDER RAZA
Edited by Ashok Vajpeyi
MAPIN AND THE RAZA FOUNDATION
₹3,500; 295 pages

Expressionism and Cubism, the post-war École de Paris, American abstract expressionism and Raza's own, unique, post-abstract expressionism. While absorbing western influences, Raza's work also stays in dialogue throughout with Indian traditions, especially Indian miniature painting, Tantric graphics and yantra mappings.

The essays in the book take us through the artist's biographical arc with which many of us are by now quite familiar: the childhood in central India, being brought up as a Forest Officer's son, the early training in small-town art schools, the move to a vibrant Bombay on the cusp of multiple upheavals, including Partition, the Indian People's Theatre Association (IPTA) movement and the growing entanglement with contemporary European and American visual art, the founding by Raza and other artists, also now famous, of the Progressive Artists Group, his move to Paris and the more than half a century of living and working between France and India. Copiously illustrated essays by Yashodhara Dalmia, Roobina Karode, Ashvin Rajagopalan, Homi Bhabha, Gayatri Sinha and Ashok Vajpeyi delve into different aspects of Raza's work; another section has extracts from other writings on Raza. There is also a section that gives us writings by Raza himself, some of his correspondence with his wife, his meditation on his own work, extracts from his notebooks; and then there is a section where letters by other artists to Raza are reproduced.

All this is extremely engaging and satisfying, but it's nothing compared to the Catalogue section, where one can explore a truly comprehensive collection of the paintings themselves. While the writing around the work is both informative and illuminating, any owner of the book will spend long and happy hours flicking back and forth between the 100 paintings fully reproduced here, as well as the illustrated timeline with which the book concludes. Watching one of the most profound and adventurous painting hands change over 70 years is truly rewarding: one can unearth here several visual stories, plots and subplots made up of line and colour and that indefinable 'something else' that Raza constantly searched for and so often found. ■

Ruchir Joshi